

THE UNICORN

Monoceros



SIZE RANKING 35

BRIGHTEST STAR
Alpha (α) 3.9GENITIVE
Monocerotis

ABBREVIATION Mon

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 PM
January–FebruaryFULLY VISIBLE
78°N–78°S

Monoceros is often overlooked, because it is overshadowed by neighboring Orion, Gemini, and Canis Major. It is easy to locate, however, since it is situated on the celestial equator in the middle of the large triangle formed by the brilliant 1st-magnitude stars Betelgeuse (in Orion), Procyon (in Canis Minor), and Sirius (in Canis Major).

Although none of the stars of Monoceros is bright, the Milky Way passes through it and it contains many deep-sky objects of interest.

The constellation was introduced in the early 17th century by the Dutch astronomer and cartographer Petrus Plancius and depicts the unicorn, a mythical animal with religious symbolism.

SPECIFIC FEATURES

Beta (β) Monocerotis (see p.281) is regarded as one of the finest triple stars in the sky for small instruments. It is readily separated to show an arc of three 5th-magnitude stars.

The double star Epsilon (ϵ) Monocerotis is labeled 8 Monocerotis on some charts. Its components, of 4th and 7th magnitudes, are easily spotted through a small telescope.

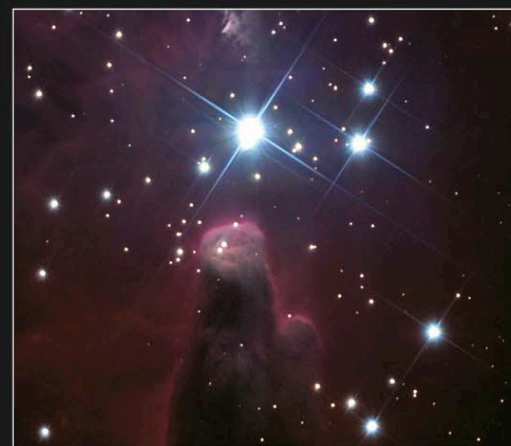
Prime among Monoceros's most celebrated clusters and nebulae is NGC 2244, an elongated group of stars of 6th magnitude and fainter. Surrounding the cluster is a glorious nebula known as the Rosette Nebula, although it

is faint and seen well only on CCD images and photographs.

NGC 2264 is another combination of open cluster and nebula. This triangular group can be seen through binoculars or a small telescope. Its brightest member is 5th-magnitude S Monocerotis—an intensely hot and luminous star that is slightly variable. CCD images and photographs show a surrounding nebulosity into which encroaches a dark wedge called the Cone Nebula (see p.242).

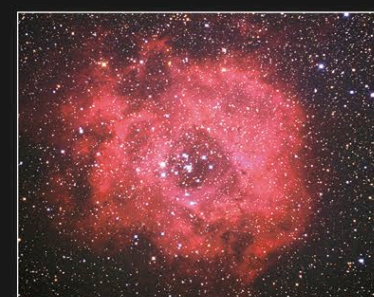
M50 is an open cluster about half the apparent size of a full moon. It is visible through binoculars, but a telescope is needed to resolve its individual stars.

NGC 2232 is larger and more scattered, and its brightest stars are visible through binoculars.



THE CONE NEBULA 𐄂 𐄂 𐄂

This tapering region of dark gas and dust intrudes into brighter nebulosity at the southern end of the star cluster NGC 2264. The Cone Nebula is visible only on images taken with a large telescope, as here.

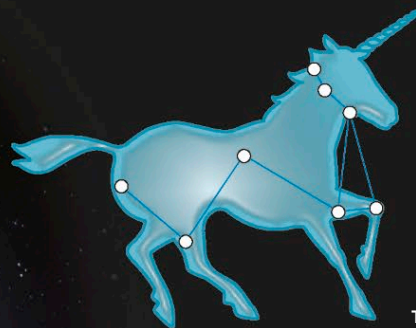


THE ROSETTE NEBULA 𐄂 𐄂

The flowerlike form of the Rosette Nebula glows like a pink carnation in this CCD image. At its center is the star cluster NGC 2244, which can readily be identified through binoculars.

FRAMED BEAST 𐄂

Monoceros occupies the space within the bright triangle of stars formed by Sirius (seen here at upper right), Betelgeuse (upper left), and Procyon (bottom center).



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